BREGUET MAKES TIME FLOAT

To mark 225 years since Abraham-Louis Breguet patented the tourbillon, the maison turns its most famous invention into theatre with the mysterious, platinum-cased Classique Tourbillon Sidéral 7255.

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Breguet does not merely have history with the tourbillon; it has custody of the original idea. Abraham-Louis Breguet was granted the patent for his rotating regulator on June 26, 1801, after devising a solution to the positional errors gravity imposed on pocket watches. Two hundred and twenty-five years later, the complication has become the haute horlogerie shorthand for technical ambition, but at Breguet it carries a little more weight. The maison's anniversary quartet makes that point without lapsing into museum-piece solemnity. There is the compact 35mm Classique Tourbillon 7357, the blue-bathed Tradition Tourbillon 7047 with its chain-and-fusee transmission, and the Marine Tourbillon Équation Marchante 5887, whose luminous star-chart dial is about as discreet as a midnight sky over the Mediterranean.

Yet the watch that best captures Breguet's peculiar ability to make engineering look like sorcery is the Classique Tourbillon Sidéral 7255. The 38mm platinum case is cool, restrained and almost severe, until the black aventurine Grand Feu enamel dial catches the light and starts behaving like a pocket galaxy. Rhodium-plated numerals and hands keep the palette deliberately icy, while the familiar fluted caseband and welded lugs ensure the watch still speaks fluent Breguet. It is limited to just 50 pieces, which feels appropriate: this is not the sort of object that benefits from becoming common scenery.

The real trick, however, happens at six o'clock. This is Breguet's first flying tourbillon rendered as a "mysterious" display, with sapphire components hiding much of the mechanism's support so the regulator appears to hover above the dial. It actually rises 0.9mm above the enamel surface, making the illusion even more theatrical. Beneath it sits the hand-wound calibre 187M1, good for 50 hours and beating at a traditional 2.5Hz. Plenty of tourbillons demonstrate mechanical virtuosity. The 7255 does something rarer: it turns virtuosity into atmosphere. For a complication born to fight gravity, this one looks remarkably happy floating.